

cided to exit.” While in the US, Raju was exposed to the likes of ABC, NBC, and CBS. “I liked the name ABC and that was the inspiration to call the company Associated Broadcasting Company. TV9 came from my liking for Channel 9 in Australia,” he explains.

Industry trackers give ABCPL credit for moving early into the markets of Karnataka (2006), Gujarat (2007) and Maharashtra (2011), when there were hardly any players. “It gave them a strong position and they smartly capitalised on that,” says one of them. TV9 Bharatvarsh was launched in 2019, while Bangla went live two years later. “We wanted to enter Tamil Nadu but the monopoly of cable distribution (owned by the Sun TV Network) was a challenge,” says Raju.

ICRA’s report highlights ABCPL’s high dependence on advertisement revenue since its channels are free-to-air. “That dependence is expected to be at similar levels [to the competition]. Also, it is exposed to intense competition in the broadcasting industry and from the digital space, which in turn impacts the market share, ad pricing, and ultimately ad revenues for the company,” says the report. **BT**

is clear about the strategic rationale. “There will be a huge requirement in India for green energy. When we bought into the company, it was a very small business,” he says. Since then, the company’s revenue and share price have increased (*see accompanying graphics*). “As a country, our oil and gas import is substantial, and converting that to electricity interests me. However, this is a long-gestation business, and one must be patient.”

Analysts tracking Olectra note that it has orders for 8,088 electric buses from state and

central bodies. Olectra is also setting up a factory in Telangana’s Seetharampur (its first factory is in Hyderabad). Olectra gets traction from its joint venture with China’s BYD, the world’s largest electric vehicles company, in which Berkshire Hathaway, the holding company of billionaire investor Warren Buffett, has invested. “We have a lot of ideas and are keen to do battery storage. There is also a technical partnership with Reliance for a hydrogen bus project,” he says.

Saji John, research analyst at Geojit BNP Paribas, says Olectra’s order book is healthy. “That gives the company revenue visibility, and revenues can double in FY25 if execution is good,” he

explains. The challenges could largely be around the availability of semi-conductors. “We have large players like Tata and CG Power getting into the space, but that will take three to four years. Until then, there will be a high dependence on China.”

BYD’s presence has given Olectra the confidence to expand its product line in e-mobility with electric tipper trucks and the hydrogen bus.

“We will experiment with many ideas, and of 10 businesses we enter, two

or three may not work,” Reddy says. Take the case of aviation, where MEIL acquired a stake in TruJet, an airline that began operations in 2015. TruJet bet on connecting small towns. “It did not work out because of the pandemic, and we realised it was not our cup of tea,” he explains. In mid-2022, MEIL sold TruJet to WinAir. “We do not have the expertise to run an airline, and there is no question of getting back to the business,” says Reddy quite firmly.

As for the way forward, he says he has his hands full and thinks getting MEIL listed is possible. But please, no timeline. “We have 2,000 km of road projects, and under PM-KUSUM, we are doing 2 GW of projects,” he says. PM-KUSUM helps farmers instal solar-powered pumps.

Just how long can he continue to do this? “I am not on social media and sleep very well for eight hours. I work six and a half days a week, and that tells you how much I love what I do.” For the extremely low-profile Reddy, there is no lack of ambition. Now that he is in the news thanks to his electoral bond contributions, his moves will not go unnoticed. That is a certainty. **BT**

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